Session 11

2025-04-27

1 - The path to Elturel

~10:00, 27 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The night's long rest at the keep runs late — the party is wrung out enough that they only rise mid-morning. Down in the common room of the keep the party finds it thick with the garrison and with villagers from the nearby settlements come in to help with the reconstruction, materials moving in and out at pace. They pick at the cold food left over from breakfast.
2. **Tarbaw Nighthill** greets them warmly — glad they are back and in better shape than the last time. He can't share their morning — the reconstruction has him stretched — but he reminds them that **Leosin** is expecting them at Elturel.
3. Tarbaw lays out the road. **Leosin** left them fresh horses and provisions prepaid at the stables — the Greenest mounts and Miguel's escort go back with Tarbaw, and at Nyx's suggestion a small cart is worked into the loadout for the heavier gear. The route runs northeast to the Trade Way, following the river through Berdusk and Scornubel, then west to Elturel — safer, though a small detour. The alternative, cross-country, cuts the distance but there are no patrols, and the horses will suffer.
   Amidamaru votes for the safer road — he is tired of monsters, and tired of fighting. Eguzkilore agrees, Nyx concurs, and Mialee falls in. Six days by road.
4. Amidamaru asks after a courier for a letter to *Westgate*, his home city. Tarbaw's guidance: no local messenger reaches that far — the letter is best carried by the party themselves as far as **Berdusk**, where east-bound merchants will pick it up.
5. Before leaving, Eguzkilore restocks arrows at the keep. Mialee buys twenty pieces of incense at a gold piece each — the ritual components she will need to summon a new familiar. Eguzkilore also exchanges his coin at the keep.

2 - Open countryside

~14:00, 27 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Once on the road the day passes quietly — no soul crossed all day, despite the good weather. To the south, grain-plains and vineyards; to the north, cattle-pastures dotted with small groves, where herds of cows and sheep graze.
2. On the ride, Sinsong pulls Amidamaru aside and starts telling him stories from his cave days — a rambling account of a colleague named Juan who fell into a hole and had to be pulled out by the leg. Amidamaru, only half-listening, works a small tinker-craft over his hood so it starts emitting a constant sound of sea-waves and wind, and leaves the trick running. The rest of the party, further along the line, can hear the sound of the sea over Sinsong's voice, gulls and all, even though the river is closer than the sea.
3. By dusk the party has covered a good stretch of country but the Chionthar is still far ahead — they pull off the road into the shelter of one of the small groves and make camp for the night: horses picketed at the tree-line, saddles pulled and stacked, a low fire kept small against the autumn chill, and watches shared out around it. Beside the fire Mialee performs the ritual to summon a new familiar — she calls up **Echo** the bat again, then folds it back into rest to travel with her come morning.

3 - The Chionthar ford

~09:00, 28 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. In the morning the party breaks camp and continues northeast, reaching the Chionthar at noon — a broad, slow river; they take the horses through the ford in file. The road picks up on the far bank and holds the same quiet countryside as before.
2. The crossing takes the rest of the afternoon, and by the time all six are on the far bank the light is already thinning. Rather than push on, they pitch camp shortly past the ford on open ground beside the Trade Way — broader and better graded than the Greenest track they'd come in on — no grove in reach. Horses picketed close, saddles for pillows, a smaller fire than the night before against a colder wind out of the north; watches shared in shorter turns and no one straying far from the light.

4 – Reaching Berdusk

~09:00, 29 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Dawn breaks over the camp; the party is back on the Trade Way by first light. Four hours of steady march, then an hour's rest at midday to eat and let the horses breathe. Five more hours in the saddle after — the last of them a forced march as the light thins, riders and mounts alike beginning to labour, to gain Berdusk before dusk.
2. Approaching the walls, Amidamaru shifts his shape — the tortle vanishes into the appearance of a heavy-built, muscled elf so that the party's shape does not catch the town's eye. Once inside, the crowd looks Nuberroca over, but between his size and the disguised tortle beside him, no one presses.
3. Amidamaru asks around the trade-quarter for a merchant heading east and settles on one whose feeling is right; the courier fee comes to five gold, and Amidamaru pays six to speed the letter on.
4. Sinsong asks after the wounded — anyone missing an arm or a leg from the recent raids. The town has plenty of maimed folk still living — but Sinsong has no means to restore lost limbs, and lets it lie.
5. The party takes the night at a tavern for two gold per head — dinner, the room, and next morning's breakfast included.

5 – Sinsong's confessions

~09:00?, 30 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. On the road again, Sinsong turns his stories on Nyx. He explains — in the language of *warlocks*, which he thinks apply to him now — the fate of his tribe: a black stone found by his master; whoever touched it began petrifying over the course of about fourteen days; the chief touched it, then most of the tribe, half of them ended in stone. Sinsong is the only one still whole, and searches for a cure — that is why he left the cave. Nyx presses on where the stone is now: *"You're not carrying it on you, are you?"*. Sinsong dodges the answer; Nyx spurs her horse and puts a little distance between them.
2. Amidamaru moves alongside Nuberroca and offers to touch the goliath's talisman and make it glow — he had promised as much. Nuberroca thanks him and asks whether the same trick could also serve on *another* object he wears: a tribal piece the size of a bracelet, worn at the base of the pelvis since his coming of age — the goblin-sized belt he keeps under his clothing. Amidamaru misreads Nuberroca's request for a small illumination and lays an *invisibility* on him instead.
3. Nuberroca, invisible, keeps riding — his horse plodding on with no rider on view. The rest of the party sees the horse of Nuberroca advancing alongside Amidamaru's with no one atop it, and cannot tell where the goliath has gone. Nyx guesses Nuberroca has fallen off.
4. Nyx, watching Sinsong's rambling from a distance, quietly pulls a bottle of vodka from her pack — *"por si quiero beber después de la conversación que he escuchado"*.
5. Eventually Nuberroca finds Amidamaru, taps his shoulder, and asks him to fix the spell that came out wrong — offering the bracelet itself into his hand to try again. Amidamaru reminds Nuberroca that the talisman is already glowing — he'd made that first. For the second piece — Sinsong will need to help; a ruby of fifty gold in dust would let him mend it properly. Nuberroca pockets the talisman inside his neckerchief and rides on.

6 - The light of Elturel

~19:00?, 30 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Forcing the horses again, the party pushes to reach Scornubel that same day rather than camp on the road again. As they close on the city and the sun starts to set in the west, a strange thing happens — the sun's usual red fade holds, but the light beyond it does not go out. Where twilight should have taken over, a white light lingers from the west, brighter than lamplight.
2. Inside the walls, Mialee stops the first townsman she finds and asks about the light. He picks them for southerners — they must be new here. It is *the light of Elturel*, he tells them; it protects the city and the whole region. He knows nothing more of how it works — he has never been to Elturel; the light has always been there. Sinsong presses: it has been shining twenty-five years and the man has never walked up to look at it — who set it there? The townsman only shrugs.
3. Scornubel itself is a walled town but not a serious fortification — a low stone wall, the river running straight through with no grille to stop the passage of boats, arches only. The main street cuts north from the southern entry across the river; the road west toward Elturel that the party will take next is a poorer, less-travelled trade route by comparison.

7 - Scornubel

1. The party takes rooms at a tavern for the night — Amidamaru pays half the going rate to share the room with Sinsong. Amidamaru re-casts his *disguise* before going down to gather information; Sinsong lays a *silver-tongue* blessing on him, quickening his tongue for the questions to come.
2. Amidamaru works the merchants for word of dragons across the region. Most talk of the raids near Greenfields — the same beat that came through Greenest. But one man's account carries weight: a village to the north was hit alongside the bandits by a red dragon. Nyx notes what the party already knows — the dragon they met was blue. Amidamaru returns to the tavern chilled by the two colours.
3. Mialee, meanwhile, questions merchants about a large caravan with carts drawn by giant lizards or draconids. None have crossed one — they know the giant lizards are used by lizardfolk in the northern marshes, but no honest trader has ever seen them working the Trade Way. *Not around here, that's for sure*.
4. Sinsong, back at the tavern, presses Eguzkilore for detail on the family arms he searches for — a dagger, a sword, and a bow, lost across generations. Eguzkilore has never seen them and has no lead — *he knows they exist*.
5. Sinsong fashions small trinkets — painted stones with a single eye on each, tokens of friendship for the party. He offers one to Nyx and one to Nuberroca and starts crafting more for the others. Nyx accepts hers, mildly amused.
6. As they turn in for the night the party discusses their sleeping arrangements — light armour off, heavy armour off, Amidamaru locked in his shell with a chair braced against the door, Eguzkilore keeping his mail and only four hours of trance.

8 – Four figures

~11:30, 1 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The party leaves Scornubel late in the morning and rides out onto a poorer, less-travelled road that runs through an old, dry valley, mountains rising on one side, the river paralleling on the other. The Light of Elturel stays with them from the west — a small sun above the city — and with the morning sun in the east, the party cast no shadows.
2. Amidamaru and Mialee send their familiars up to scout the road ahead — **Munin** the owl on the wing above, **Echo** the bat flitting between the rocks — the party rides on behind them.
3. About fifty or sixty feet ahead, four figures stand across the road, one larger than the others. Nyx asks if she can spot anyone hidden further on; too far to tell from where they sit. The river cuts them off to the left; the valley walls to the right could be climbed but not by horse without risk.
4. Nuberroca dismisses the pause — worse than four men have failed to stop them; on they ride. *"¿Quién dijo miedo?"*. He advances alone on horseback, then dismounts and takes up the pike and shield.

9 – The ambush turned

~17:30, 1 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The leader — an older man, calm, moving with the ease of someone who has done this many times — hails them and offers the party his group's protection in exchange for a modest fee, warning of the road's monsters and stray bandits. Nuberroca answers in the language he understands: *"Perfecto, ¿dónde hay bandidos? Tengo nuevas armas que quiero probar"*. He steps another pace closer.
2. From behind, Amidamaru shapes a small illusion that places a whispered voice at Nuberroca's ear — *enemies on the left*. Nuberroca glances left, then turns back to the older man: *"Insecto, si no quieres perder tu vida ni la de los que tienes escondidos alrededor, déjanos pasar y pasaremos esta afrenta de largo. Es tu última oportunidad"*. He squares up, ready to loose the blood-fury the moment steel comes out.
3. The old man's face changes — not fear, only a small note of resignation: *if not the easy way, then the hard one*. In one fluid, practised motion he draws his crossbow and steps backward; the three companions with him ready weapons of their own and the fight is on.
4. The first bolt sails wide of Nuberroca; the shooter fumbles his crossbow to the ground with the recoil. Nyx, holding her shot for the leader, releases in the same breath — the arrow threads clean into him where he stands.
5. Nuberroca, furious, answers with the pike, splitting the bandit nearest him and lifting the body clean off the polearm's tip; the follow-up haft-strike cracks the second bandit down to reeling.
6. Mialee's arrow slips out of her hand as she draws with nerves; she picks it up, moves, and casts a bank of white fog across the middle of the field, heavily obscuring the ledges' line of fire. The bandits shift to cover — one bolt lands wide between Eguzkilore and Sinsong, and another finds Amidamaru with savage force.
7. Sinsong, riding into the middle, calls a blessing over Nuberroca, Amidamaru and Eguzkilore and then — for one still moment — asks the leader across the battle to stop: *"please, we can end this slaughter. No one has to suffer"*. Amidamaru remarks aloud, half in wonder, that this is the first time Sinsong has not opened combat with an attack.
8. Amidamaru, dismounting against the valley wall, calls up a *shadow blade* — he grips the hilt at his belt and a black-edged blade seems to grow from it — and lands a first cut on the captain.
9. Eguzkilore catches his breath, takes a first shot at the leader, then looses a second in the same instant — the two arrows together open the man deep, more damage in that one turn than anyone else has landed on him.
10. Sinsong folds an *emboldening bond* across the party, then picks one of the two bandits crouched atop the cliff and threads a *fire bolt* up at him — the strike catches and the man falls from the ledge.

10 - The last runner

1. With the leader bleeding out on the ground, Nuberroca closes on him and pins him under his weight — the captain cannot break free and is bound where he lies. Amidamaru finishes it: pommel-strikes from the *shadow blade*'s hilt to the nape and the captain slumps unconscious. Between the arrows Eguzkilore left in him and the beating, he is a hair from death.
2. One bandit is still standing on the ledge above the road; he turns and runs, scrambling up the rocks toward the ridge line. Sinsong rides up beneath him and casts a spell of slumber onto the climbing man — the spell takes, and the bandit crashes down the rocks, badly battered by the fall.
3. Sinsong calls after the sleeping man — *wait, we can still be friends*. Nuberroca will have none of it and urges Nyx to shoot.
4. ***[EPIC]*** Nyx lowers her bow: *"no le voy a disparar. Se va a contar la historia de cómo hemos aniquilado a una banda de bandidos"*. She stays her hand, and turns instead to recovering the arrows she'd fired.
5. Nuberroca draws his crossbow and shoots the man cleanly. *"Cuando entras en la batalla, no puedes huir como un cobarde"*.
6. Amidamaru searches the captain for cult iconography or a talisman — nothing along those lines, but he does find a small stash of precious stones. He passes them to Nuberroca for his collection; Nuberroca thanks him warmly — *"Muchas gracias, hombre-tortuga"*.
7. Sinsong asks Nuberroca to borrow the small whistle Nyx had given him; Nuberroca agrees but complains his wounds hurt, and Amidamaru quietly casts a healing touch on him from behind. Sinsong claims the credit, but the goliath doesn't buy it and turns to thank Amidamaru.

11 - Taifoz's story

~18:00, 1 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The party ropes the captain into the cart and rides on; an hour of the road passes before he stirs. When he finally tries to move against the ropes, his wounds pull sharp and he goes still with a low pained sound. He speaks — *up until a few hours ago he worked for himself; he is unemployed now. If they need a guard, or a guide, he is good at both*.
2. He calls the whole encounter a terrible misunderstanding — his party had been offering their trade in escort along the caravan road, and Nuberroca had come in charging with a spear. Nuberroca answers — *they are bandits, and they had tried to rob the party of their goods*. Nyx cuts in: *"te empezamos a entender mal cuando sacaste la ballesta y nos apuntaste"*.
3. The man offers, without shame, to serve them — twenty gold, then eighteen — as guide and guard as far north as Waterdeep. Nyx sees him for what he is; Mialee wants him delivered to Elturel's authorities; Sinsong finds him convincing; Nuberroca wants a duel once he has healed. Amidamaru and Nyx both read him closely — he is *convinced of what he is saying*, which is not the same thing as telling the truth.
4. He gives his name — **Taifoz** — and names three sons, two at Elturel, one at Baldur's Gate. On the light of Elturel he speaks with confidence: an ancestral device the town's rulers set in the sky to keep the hordes of the dead away from the region. He mentions **Ontharr Frume** of the Order of the Gauntlet as *a great friend of his*. The party recognises the name from Leosin's briefing.
5. The party settles: they will take him to the gates of Elturel and let the guards handle him — Mialee rides in the cart with him, ready to move if he tries anything; Nyx trails behind with her eyes fixed on him; Sinsong rides alongside to keep him talking.

12 – Push to Elturel

~19:00, 1 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Rather than camping on the road, the party decides to force the pace to make Elturel that same night — an extra three hours of hard riding beyond the day's march.
2. The ride wears them down — horses labour, riders go sore, the party hollows out hour by hour; only Eguzkilore's soldier's discipline keeps him steady. When four of the six horses are spent, Nuberroca and Nyx give up their mounts to Sinsong and Mialee; Nuberroca takes over the exhausted horse to lead, and Nyx dismounts to walk.
3. In the changeover Mialee misjudges her fresh mount, slips out of the saddle and thumps to the ground — the fall knocks the wind and the last of her strength out at once, to a laughing groan from the party. She crawls into the cart and sleeps the rest of the ride.
4. Sinsong, spent and out of patience with Taifoz's constant pitching for release, takes a swing at his head to shut him up — *and misses, exhausted as he is*. As the walls of Elturel come clear ahead, Taifoz tries one more pitch from the cart-bed: *you should seriously consider letting me go*.

13 – The escape

~22:00, 1 Uktar 1489 DR

1. About two or three hundred metres from the gate, the walls of Elturel visible ahead and the guards atop them, Nyx, Nuberroca and Eguzkilore scan the surrounding — no one sees anything odd.
2. Then, in one motion, **Taifoz is up from the cart** — Mialee's scimitar in his hand: *you should have hired me*. He slashes at Nuberroca as he leaps free and turns to run for the woods.
3. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca kicks his horse into a gallop and runs the escaping man down before he can clear the road. He drops off the horse on top of Taifoz in a wrestling tackle, wrapping him under his weight. He holds back the killing blow this time — the goliath knocks Taifoz unconscious with the impact and the fists that follow.
4. The guards on the wall watched it all and had crossbows ready — but they let it play out, seeing the direction of it. Nuberroca hoists the unconscious captain across his back and calls up to the gatehouse: *"Perdonad, buenos señores — traemos un bandido y hemos tenido un pequeño incidente"*.

14 – The Black Antler

1. One of the wall-guards comes down to meet them; when he sees Taifoz's face, he starts to laugh, calls his companion over — *look who's here* — and asks whether they have come to collect the bounty. He counts out **fifty gold pieces** into the party's cart and takes the body away. Taifoz had been raiding the region for months, always slipping the patrols — by morning his head will likely be on the gate.
2. Nuberroca tells the tale of the ambush to the guard, spinning it a touch in the party's favour; the guard takes it happily — *always good to have warriors who put an end to bandits*.
3. The guard points them to a tavern for the night — the **A Pair of Black Antlers**, a stag's head with both antlers painted black hung above the door, on the main street from the gate.
4. He tells them the place is the favoured hangout of the **Order of the Gauntlet** — a military order that supports the city guard, better-equipped than most because they have money behind them; noisy people, fond of tournaments of strength and skill, but good guys. Their local leader is **Ontharr Frume**, a paladin the guard names as one of the best warriors alive.
5. Amidamaru asks about other outstanding bounties on the road. The guard: no, most bandit trouble is on the main Trade Way and belongs to the trails further out; most travellers arrive by boat down the Chionthar because it is much faster and safer than the road.
6. Wrung out to the last — legs heavy in the stirrups, hands slack on the reins, more than one of them half-asleep in the saddle — the party turns at last toward the Antler for the night.